Hardware and Equipment Stipends Policy

Meridian Holt Group — People Operations & IT

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Hardware and Equipment Stipends Policy

1. Purpose

This policy describes what equipment Meridian Holt Group provides to employees, what stipends are available for additional purchases, how reimbursement works, and what happens to equipment when an employee's role or employment changes. It is intended to be read alongside the Remote and Hybrid Work Policy, which addresses where and how employees are expected to work, but not what they're issued to do it with — that is the subject of this document.

The guiding principle behind this policy is that employees should never be out of pocket for the tools they genuinely need to do their job well, while the Company maintains reasonable control over spend, asset tracking, and security. Where this policy sets a dollar figure, that figure is reviewed annually by Finance each November and may change from year to year; the figures below reflect the amounts current as of this policy's effective date.

2. Standard Issue Equipment

Every full-time and part-time employee, regardless of work location category, is issued the following at the start of employment, at no cost to the employee and without drawing on any stipend:

- One Company laptop, selected from a standard set of configurations maintained by IT. Engineering and Data roles receive a higher-specification configuration by default (32GB RAM minimum); all other roles receive a standard configuration (16GB RAM) unless a manager requests an upgrade for a documented business reason, such as video editing work in Marketing.
- One external monitor, for employees who will work primarily from a home office or a hybrid arrangement; employees who work primarily from a Company office may instead use a monitor provided at their desk and are not separately issued one for home use unless they are hybrid and split time meaningfully between locations.
- A standard keyboard, mouse, and laptop stand.
- A headset suitable for video calls.

Standard issue equipment remains Company property at all times and must be returned upon separation from the Company, as described in Section 7. Employees should not expect to keep standard issue equipment after their last day, with the narrow exception described in that section for long-tenured employees in specific circumstances.

3. The Home Office Stipend

In addition to standard issue equipment, employees classified as Hybrid or Fully Remote (see the Remote and Hybrid Work Policy for definitions) are eligible for a Home Office Stipend to cover additional items the Company does not issue directly, such as a desk, an ergonomic chair, additional monitors beyond the one standard-issue unit, lighting for video calls, or a better home

internet connection.

The Home Office Stipend is currently set at $1,000 USD (or the equivalent in local currency for employees paid outside the United States, calculated using the exchange rate published by Finance on the first business day of the calendar year) for an employee's first year in a hybrid or fully remote role, and $350 USD per year thereafter for replacement or upgrade of home office items. The stipend is not a cash allowance added to payroll; it is a reimbursable expense category, meaning employees purchase the item themselves and submit for reimbursement through the Expense system, selecting "Home Office Stipend" as the category, with an itemized receipt attached.

Unused stipend does not roll over from one year to the next, and does not convert to cash under any circumstances. An employee who spends $600 of their first-year $1,000 stipend forfeits the remaining $400; it cannot be carried into year two on top of that year's $350 allotment.

3.1 What the Home Office Stipend Covers

Eligible purchases include: desks and desk risers, office chairs, monitor arms and additional monitors, desk lamps and ring lights for video calls, webcams and microphones (beyond the standard-issue headset), ergonomic accessories such as wrist rests and footrests, and a portion of home internet service upgrades specifically undertaken to support remote work (for example, upgrading from a basic plan to one with sufficient upload bandwidth for video calls).

3.2 What the Home Office Stipend Does Not Cover

The stipend may not be used for: general home furniture not used for work (a couch, a bed, decorative items); recurring monthly costs other than the internet upgrade described above (electricity, rent, coffee); equipment that duplicates something already issued by the Company (a second Company-specification laptop, for example); or any item for a household member who is not the employee. Employees found to have submitted personal, non-work-related purchases under the Home Office Stipend may be required to repay the amount and may face disciplinary action under the Code of Conduct's section on accurate records.

4. Equipment Refresh Cycle

Company-issued laptops are refreshed on a 3-year cycle by default. IT proactively reaches out to schedule a replacement when a laptop approaches the end of this cycle; employees do not need to request a refresh unless their current equipment is failing to meet their needs sooner than the standard cycle, in which case they should open a ticket with IT describing the issue. IT may approve an early refresh where there is a legitimate performance or reliability problem, a change in job requirements (for example, an employee moving into a role that requires the higher-specification configuration), or a documented accommodation need.

Monitors, keyboards, mice, and other peripherals are replaced on an as-needed basis when they fail or are lost, rather than on a fixed schedule, since they generally have a longer useful life than laptops and failure is a better signal than age for when to replace them.

5. Mobile Phone and Cellular Stipend

Employees whose role requires regular use of a personal mobile phone for Company business — for example, Sales employees who need to be reachable by client contacts, or Engineering employees on an on-call rotation — are eligible for a Mobile Stipend of $50 USD per month, paid through payroll as a taxable stipend rather than through expense reimbursement. Eligibility for the Mobile Stipend is determined by role and must be approved by the employee's manager; it is not automatically granted to every employee, since not every role genuinely requires business use of a personal phone. Employees who believe their role qualifies but who are not currently

receiving the stipend should raise this with their manager.

The Company does not, as a general practice, issue Company-owned mobile phones, except to a small number of roles with specific security or compliance requirements, such as members of the Security team who carry a dedicated device for incident response.

6. Software and SaaS Tool Requests

Software licenses are requested through the IT portal rather than funded through any stipend described in this document. Standard software (email, calendar, the Company's core productivity suite, Slack, and role-appropriate tools like an IDE for Engineering or a design tool for Product/Design) is provisioned automatically at hire based on job title. Requests for additional software — a specialized analytics tool, an AI coding assistant beyond the Company-wide default, a niche design plugin — require manager approval and, for any tool that will touch customer data, a Security review before purchase, regardless of the dollar amount involved. Employees should never enter a personal credit card for a Company software subscription with the intention of expensing it later, since this bypasses the Security review process; software must be requested and reviewed before purchase, not after.

7. Equipment Return Upon Separation

All Company-issued equipment — laptops, monitors, peripherals, and any other asset tracked in the IT Asset Management system — must be returned within 10 business days of an employee's last day of employment, regardless of the reason for separation. IT provides a prepaid shipping label for remote and hybrid employees who need to return equipment by mail; office-based employees typically return equipment in person as part of offboarding.

As a narrow exception, employees with more than seven years of tenure at the time of a voluntary resignation in good standing may request to purchase their Company laptop at its depreciated fair market value, as determined by IT Asset Management, rather than returning it; this exception does not apply to monitors or other peripherals, and does not apply to involuntary separations of any kind. Requests under this exception must be submitted before the employee's last day and are processed by IT and Finance together.

Equipment not returned within the required window, absent an approved exception, may result in the depreciated value of the equipment being deducted from final pay to the extent permitted by applicable law in the employee's jurisdiction, or being billed directly to the former employee where payroll deduction is not legally permitted.

8. Lost, Stolen, or Damaged Equipment

Employees should report lost, stolen, or significantly damaged Company equipment to IT as soon as possible; for a lost or stolen device specifically, this should also be reported to IT Security within one hour of discovery, per the Information Security requirements referenced in the Remote and Hybrid Work Policy, so that the device can be remotely locked or wiped if it contains Company data. A single incident of loss or theft, reported promptly and in good faith, is treated as a normal cost of doing business and does not result in any charge to the employee. A pattern of repeated loss or damage, or a failure to report promptly, may result in the cost of replacement being charged to the employee and may be addressed as a performance or conduct matter.

9. International Considerations

Employees based outside the United States receive equipment and stipends denominated and, where relevant, taxed according to local requirements, which can mean a stipend that is

functionally equivalent in value but structured differently for local payroll and tax purposes (for example, in some countries a home office stipend must be paid through payroll rather than as an expense reimbursement, due to local tax rules). Employees with questions about how this policy applies in their specific country should contact their HRBP, since Finance and People Operations maintain country-specific implementation guidance that is not reproduced in full here.

10. Questions and Exceptions

Requests for equipment or stipend arrangements not explicitly covered by this policy — for example, a specialized accessibility device, or equipment needed for a temporary project outside an employee's normal role — should be directed to the employee's manager and HRBP, who can evaluate the request against the general principles in Section 1 even where a specific rule does not exist. As with the other HR policies referenced in this document, verbal exceptions are not binding; any approved exception should be documented in writing by an HRBP or by IT Asset Management, as appropriate to the request.

11. Accessibility Equipment and Accommodations

Equipment needed as part of a documented disability accommodation — for example, an adjustable-height desk for a medical condition, specialized input devices, screen-reading software, or a sit-stand workstation prescribed by a medical provider — is funded separately from the standard Home Office Stipend described in Section 3, through the Reasonable Accommodation Policy, and does not draw down an employee's stipend balance. Employees should not attempt to fund accommodation-related equipment out of the standard Home Office Stipend even if it would technically fit within the eligible categories in Section 3.1, both because the stipend amount may be insufficient for specialized equipment and because accommodation requests carry additional legal protections that the standard stipend process does not track. Employees seeking an accommodation should start the request with People Operations rather than IT, so that the appropriate interactive process can begin.

12. Team and Department-Specific Equipment

Beyond the individual stipends described elsewhere in this policy, some departments maintain additional equipment budgets specific to their function, managed by department leadership rather than through the individual employee stipend process. Examples include: the Hardware Engineering lab equipment budget, which funds shared testing equipment, prototyping tools, and lab safety gear; the Sales team's client-demo equipment pool, which funds a limited number of loaner devices used specifically for in-person client demonstrations; and the Design team's shared budget for specialized creative hardware such as drawing tablets and color-calibrated external monitors, which supplements rather than replaces the standard individual stipend.

Employees with questions about whether a piece of equipment should be requested through their individual Home Office Stipend or through a department budget should ask their manager, since the right path depends on whether the equipment is used primarily by one person (individual stipend) or shared across a team (department budget).

13. Expense Reimbursement Process and Timelines

Reimbursement requests submitted under the Home Office Stipend follow the same Expense system used for all other Company reimbursements. To be reimbursed, an employee must submit the request within 90 days of the purchase date; requests submitted after this window may be denied at Finance's discretion, so employees are encouraged to submit promptly rather than accumulating receipts. Each request must include an itemized receipt (a credit card statement alone is not sufficient, since it does not show what was purchased) and a brief note describing

how the item supports the employee's home office setup.

Approved reimbursements are typically paid out within the next two payroll cycles following submission and manager approval. Employees who do not see a reimbursement reflected within this window should first check the status in the Expense system before contacting Finance directly, since most delays are due to a pending manager approval step rather than a Finance processing issue.

14. Equipment for Temporary and Contract Workers

Contractors and temporary workers engaged directly by the Company (as opposed to through a staffing agency that provides its own equipment) are generally issued a Company laptop for the duration of the engagement but are not eligible for the Home Office Stipend described in Section 3, the Mobile Stipend described in Section 5, or the equipment-purchase exception described in Section 7, all of which are benefits tied to employee status. Hiring managers who believe a specific contractor engagement genuinely requires stipend-equivalent support should raise this with their HRBP and Finance before the engagement begins, so it can be addressed through the contractor's rate or statement of work rather than through an ad hoc exception to this policy after the fact.

15. Environmental and Asset-Lifecycle Considerations

Equipment returned to IT Asset Management under Section 7, and equipment retired at the end of its useful life, is handled according to the Company's e-waste and data-sanitization procedures: all storage is securely wiped using industry-standard data destruction methods before any device is resold, donated, or recycled, and devices that still have useful life remaining are, where practical, donated to a Company-partnered nonprofit technology reuse program rather than being discarded. Employees do not need to take any action related to this process beyond returning equipment through the normal channels described in Section 7; IT Asset Management handles data sanitization and disposal centrally to ensure it is done consistently and securely.

16. Annual Review and Budget Adjustments

The dollar figures in this policy — including the Home Office Stipend amounts in Section 3 and the Mobile Stipend in Section 5 — are reviewed by Finance and People Operations each November as part of the annual budget cycle, taking into account inflation, changes in typical home office equipment pricing, and feedback gathered through the annual employee engagement survey's benefits section. Any change to stipend amounts takes effect at the start of the following calendar year and is communicated to all employees at least 30 days in advance, consistent with the general policy-change communication standard described elsewhere in Company HR policies. Employees should treat the specific dollar figures in this document as current only as of its stated effective date and should check the HR portal's benefits summary page for the most up-to-date figures if there is any doubt.

17. Frequently Asked Questions

I'm hybrid and only occasionally work from home — am I still eligible for the Home Office Stipend? Yes. Eligibility is based on work-location classification (Hybrid or Fully Remote), not on the number of days actually worked from home in a given week, since even occasional home-based work benefits from a reasonably set-up workspace.

Can I use the stipend to buy equipment for a household member, like a partner who also works from home? No. The stipend is issued per employee and may only be used for equipment the employee themselves uses for Company work, per Section 3.2.

What if I switch from Hybrid to Office-Based — do I need to return equipment purchased with the stipend? No. Items purchased through the Home Office Stipend, unlike standard-issue Company equipment described in Section 2, are considered the employee's personal property once reimbursed and do not need to be returned if work-location classification changes later.

My laptop is having performance issues but it's only 18 months old — can I still request a refresh? Yes, through the process described in Section 4; age alone is not what triggers a refresh, a genuine performance or reliability issue is sufficient grounds to open an IT ticket regardless of how new the device is.

18. Illustrative Scenarios

Scenario A — An employee wants to buy a $1,400 ergonomic chair in their first year. The employee's first-year Home Office Stipend is $1,000 under Section 3. They may still buy the $1,400 chair, but will only be reimbursed up to $1,000, and will have no remaining stipend balance for any other item that year, since unused amounts do not roll over and the stipend does not extend beyond its stated cap for a single high-value purchase.

Scenario B — A hybrid employee splits time evenly between a Company office and home, and wants a second monitor for the office desk paid for by the stipend. Section 3 defines the Home Office Stipend as covering home office equipment; a second monitor for a Company office desk is instead requested through IT's standard office equipment process, not the individual stipend, since office desk equipment is Company-provided infrastructure rather than a personal home purchase.

Scenario C — An employee separates from the Company two weeks after receiving a laptop refresh. Standard-issue equipment remains Company property regardless of how recently it was issued; the employee must return the laptop within 10 business days of their last day per Section 7, the same as any other separating employee, unless they qualify for and successfully request the seven-year tenure purchase exception, which a two-week-old refresh recipient is very unlikely to meet given the tenure requirement.

Scenario D — An employee's home internet bill is $80 per month, and they upgraded to a $120 per month plan specifically to support video calls. Under Section 3.1, a portion of the upgrade cost undertaken specifically to support remote work is eligible; in practice, this typically means the $40 monthly difference between the prior plan and the upgraded plan is what should be submitted for reimbursement against the stipend, not the full $120 monthly bill, since the base cost of having home internet at all is a personal expense unrelated to the stipend's purpose.

Scenario E — A Sales employee who receives the Mobile Stipend switches to a role in Engineering that does not have a regular business need for phone use. Because Mobile Stipend eligibility in Section 5 is tied to role, not to the individual employee permanently, the new manager should reassess whether the stipend is still warranted as part of the role transition, and the stipend should be discontinued going forward if the new role does not meet the eligibility criteria, consistent with how the stipend was granted in the first place.

19. Governance and Policy Ownership

This policy is jointly owned by People Operations and IT Asset Management, with Finance holding approval authority over the dollar figures described in Sections 3, 5, and 7. Questions about the policy's intent or about a specific interpretation should go to People Operations; questions about a specific reimbursement submission or its status should go to Finance through the Expense system's help channel; and questions about a specific device, refresh timeline, or return logistics should go to IT. Routing questions to the right owner generally produces a faster answer than raising a general question broadly across all three teams at once.